

Message 1

The Need of a Return from Captivity

Scripture Reading: 2 Chron. 36:14-23; Ezra 1:1-5

In this message we come to the last three books of history in the Old Testament — Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther.

A brief survey of the history of Israel

I believe that in eternity past God determined that, after the confusion of Babel, He would choose a man by the name of Abraham. After calling Abraham God spent many years to train him. Eventually, Abraham produced a son, Isaac. Isaac had two sons — Esau, whom God hated, and Jacob, whom God loved (Mal. 1:2-3; Rom. 9:13). For many years Jacob was dealt with under God's hand. Jacob produced twelve sons, and these sons became the twelve tribes of Israel.

When God called Abraham out of Chaldea, the land of Babel, He promised to give him the good land, the land of Canaan (Gen. 12:1, 7), and He brought Abraham into this land. Abraham, therefore, was the first one of God's chosen people to enter into the good land. Later, the twelve tribes drifted away from the good land to Egypt, where they remained for hundreds of years (Exo. 12:40-41). During this time in Egypt, the twelve tribes of Israel became a nation of about two million people. They were usurped, enslaved, and persecuted by Pharaoh, king of Egypt. They cried out to God, and He sent Moses to deliver them out of that land of slavery into the good land. God brought the people of Israel to Mount Sinai to train them and to give them the covenant, the testament, which included both the moral law and the ceremonial law. In giving Israel the law, God's intention was that they would be a nation of priests.

When the people of Israel were about to enter into the land of Canaan, God charged them through Moses to slaughter all the Canaanites. He also charged them to destroy all the idols and everything related to idolatry. Joshua took this charge and he was faithful to it, but he was not faithful absolutely. Instead of slaughtering all the Canaanites, he allowed some to remain.

In the law given on Mount Sinai, God commanded the people of Israel concerning how to behave in relation to Him and in relation to one another. He did not want them to forsake Him, the fountain of living water, and hew out cisterns (idols) which are broken and which cannot retain water. He wanted them to love one another and not to murder, not to commit adultery, not to steal, not to lie, and not to covet. They were to take care of others, even returning lost things to their owner. This was the kind of life that was ordained by God. It was a heavenly life lived by earthly people. A people with such a living could surely be called the kingdom of God.

However, after Israel entered into the good land, they were not faithful to God. The people of Israel failed God and eventually were divided into the kingdom of Judah and the kingdom of Israel. The kingdom of Israel became apostate; they forsook God and set up other worship centers in addition to the unique center at Jerusalem. The kingdom of Israel was captured by the Assyrians, and later the kingdom of Judah was captured by the Babylonians. At that time the city of Jerusalem was captured and was not returned to Israel until 1967.

God giving up the people of Israel to captivity and promising to bring them back from captivity

At the end of 2 Chronicles, in God's eyes the condition and situation of Israel were miserable. The land was usurped and taken over by pagans, and the people of Israel were given by God as captives to the heathens. Furthermore, the temple was burned and the wall of Jerusalem was torn down. The entire good land, the so-called holy land, was devastated.

When Jeremiah saw all this, sitting on the top of Mount Zion and looking down at Jerusalem, he lamented bitterly. All the leading ones and all the noble ones of his countrymen had been taken away to captivity in Babylon, and only the poorest of the people were left to keep the land. It is no wonder that Jeremiah lamented. Eventually, he himself was taken captive to Egypt and there he was put to death. What a pitiful situation!

Such a condition lasted for seventy years, as Jeremiah himself had prophesied. While Jeremiah was lamenting, God came in to comfort him with the word that the captivity would not be forever but would last only seventy years (Jer. 25:11). God assured him that the miserable situation of his country and his people, of the temple and the city, would last for just seventy years. Some of the captured ones, such as Daniel, would still be alive at the expiration of the seventy years. When Zerubbabel led the first return from Babylon to Jerusalem, Daniel was still alive there in Babylon. Therefore, God comforted Jeremiah by assuring him that just as He gave the people up to captivity, He would also bring them back from their captivity. God would bring them back, not as captives but as triumphant warriors.

The return from captivity through the secret preserving care of the hiding God

Following 1 and 2 Chronicles, we have the books of Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther. The book of Ezra is concerned with the return to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple, and the book of Nehemiah is concerned with the repair, the rebuilding, of the city. The book of Esther shows us how the omnipresent and omnipotent God became the hiding God in protecting His captured elect, who were scattered in their captivity.

Apparently God would not do anything for His people, for He is a God who hides Himself (Isa. 45:15). This is why in the book of Esther God is not referred to by any of His divine titles. In this book there is no explicit mention of God; the word God is not even used. Yet this book shows us that God is present in a hidden way, exercising His sovereignty in the wisest manner to preserve His elect. Because of this, His elect under the persecution in their captivity could survive and multiply, in order that one day they might be brought by God to their fathers' land.

The first group returned under Zerubbabel, a descendant of David, of the royal family. He was appointed the governor of Judah by Cyrus the king. The second group returned under Ezra, a priest and a scribe. As we have pointed out, this return was made possible through the secret preserving care of the hiding God in their captivity.

God let His people be captured and then scattered in their captivity. He also let the holy land be usurped and occupied, and He left the city of Jerusalem to lie waste. Seemingly the omnipotent and omnipresent God was not doing anything for the people of Israel. Actually He was protecting and preserving them in a hidden way.

The situation is the same today regarding the Middle East. The decision concerning Israel does not rest with the politicians and statesmen but with the hidden God. One day the omnipresent and omnipotent God will appear as the Son of Man, who will come back to take possession of the earth. He will place His right foot on the sea and His left on the land (Rev. 10:1-2), indicating that He has come to take possession of the earth and the sea. This One who is coming back to the earth is Jesus Christ, the God-man. When He comes, other God-men — the overcomers — will be with Him.

The history of the people of Israel being a type of the New Testament believers as God's elect

We need to remember that all the history of the people of Israel is a type, typifying the New Testament believers as God's elect. Israel, therefore, is a type of the church. The church was established by the Lord as the Head through His apostles in the first century. Yet by the end of the first century the church became degraded. This means that the church was captured.

Even among us, individually, whoever is defeated in the spiritual life has been captured. He will remain in captivity until he repents. Through his repentance he will be brought back. If we are captured, we are captured away from the enjoyment of Christ. But our repentance brings us back to Him, back to the enjoyment of Christ.

Today we are in a situation that is typified by the situation at Ezra's time. Some of us have come back already, and others are still on the way.

Our need to be clear concerning three situations

We all need to be clear concerning three situations: the world situation, the situation of Christianity, and our situation in the Lord's recovery. The worldly empires are the usurpers, and Christianity is our opposer. We in the Lord's recovery should not consider ourselves as nothing. We know the world situation, we know the situation of Christianity, and we know the hidden God.

I have the full peace that we are in the hand of the omnipresent and omnipotent yet hiding God, who is exercising His wise sovereignty to protect us, keep us, and save us. We do not need to worry about who will oppose us or who will persecute us. We have to believe in this hiding God. He is wise and He is sovereign. He can do everything under His wise sovereignty.

An Introductory Word

Scripture Reading: Ezra 1:1-5

In this message we will give an introductory word to our life-study of Ezra.

I. Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther being the last three books of the history of God's chosen people in the Old Testament

Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther are the last three books of the history of God's chosen people in the Old Testament after 1 and 2 Chronicles. These three books all are related to God's chosen people in their captivity. The first two cover in a public way the return of God's people from their captivity (cf. Daniel, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi), and the last one presents to us a pattern of how the hidden God, in a secret way, takes care of His chosen people in their captivity.

II. The writer

The writer of the book of Ezra was Ezra, whose name means "help" or "helper." He was a descendant of Aaron (7:1-5), a priest and a scribe skilled in the law of Moses (vv. 6, 11-12). There are three Ezras in the Bible: one was a priest who returned with Zerubbabel (Neh. 12:1), one was a descendant of Caleb (1 Chron. 4:15-17), and one was the writer of this book.

III. The time

Regarding the time of writing, the contents of this book cover a period of about eighty years, from 536-457 B.C.

IV. The contents

It is very important for us to know the contents of the book of Ezra. This book gives us a record of the two returns of the children of Israel from their captivity. The first return was under Zerubbabel, a descendant of the royal family of David (chs. 1—6). Zerubbabel should have been the one to succeed the throne of David, but he was appointed to be the governor of Judah by Cyrus. The second return was under Ezra, a priest as the descendant of Aaron (chs. 7—10).

It is significant that Zerubbabel was of the royal tribe (Judah) and that Ezra was a descendant of a priestly family. The priests took care of God's speaking, and the kings took care of God's ruling. All that God has been doing is mainly in these two matters of speaking and ruling.

V. The crucial points

The book of Ezra stresses the return of the children of Israel from their captivity. This return is crucial in four points.

A. The return of the children of Israel from their captivity recovering the purpose of God's calling of them

The children of Israel were called by God and separated by God unto Himself as His testimony. Their captivity had annulled this purpose. The return of the children of Israel from their captivity recovered the purpose of God's calling of them.

As a people, the children of Israel were supposed to be a testimony of God. In what way was Israel to be a testimony to God? If we would answer this question, we need to see that the law given through Moses was called the testimony (Exo. 25:16, 21) because it is a portrait of God. As the Giver of the law, God is portrayed in the law according to what He is. In particular, the Ten Commandments are God's testimony. The ark was called the ark of the testimony (25:22; 26:33), and the tabernacle was called the tabernacle of testimony (Num. 1:50, 53).

The Ten Commandments, inscribed on two tablets of stone, are divided into two groups of five commandments, like the ten fingers on our two hands. Each group of five commandments is divided into four plus one.

In the first group, the first three commandments are concerned with God and charge us not to have any god other than God, not to worship idols, and not to take the name of God in vain. God must be the unique God to us.

The fourth commandment concerns the keeping of the Sabbath. The real significance of keeping the Sabbath is that we must stop ourselves in order to be one with God. Those who do not keep the Sabbath may gain a day for themselves, but they lose God. The commandment regarding the Sabbath is also related to God. Thus, the first four commandments are all concerned with God.

The fifth commandment, concerning honoring our parents, ranks our parents with God and points to God as our origin. Our origin is our parents, and the origin of our parents is God. When we honor our parents, we honor God. From this we see that honoring our parents is a very significant matter.

The second group of five commandments is concerned with our relationships one to another. These are the commandments not to kill, not to commit adultery, not to steal, not to lie, and not to covet. How wonderful our society would be if there were no killing, no adultery, no stealing, no lying, and no coveting. Our community would be a marvelous place if everyone was loving, pure, truthful, and helpful. A people who keep these last five commandments would surely be a real testimony of God, testifying that their God is the God of love, purity, sympathy, and truthfulness. Such a people would surely be God's particular people, God's elect, separated unto Him and sanctified to the uttermost.

After the man created by God became fallen, mankind fell lower and lower until, at Babel, they became rotten to the uttermost. God gave up the created race after Babel. Then He called Abraham and gave his descendants the law as the testimony of God. He expected that Abraham's descendants would be a people who had only Jehovah as their God, who rested with God in oneness, who honored their origin, and who loved one another in purity and honesty. Such a people would be the same as God in expression. They would be the many reproductions of God on earth testifying of the one God in heaven. This was God's purpose in calling the children of Israel and separating them to Himself. But the children of Israel failed God, breaking every one of the Ten Commandments and becoming the same as mankind.

The testimony of God is that we have one God and no other gods, that we stop ourselves in order to be one with God and to enjoy Him and have Him as everything, and that we honor Him as our origin, which is signified by our parents. Israel was carried away into captivity, and God lost such a testimony. They were called by God for the purpose of being His testimony, and their captivity annulled this purpose. But the return of the children of Israel from their captivity recovered the purpose of God's calling of them.

B. Their return from their captivity to the unique ground of Jerusalem recovering their oneness

In order to have one testimony, God always kept the children of Israel together in a narrow piece of land, not allowing them to become too great in number. They were a particular people in a particular place, and they were in oneness. But the captivity scattered them, some to Assyria, some to Egypt, and most of them to Babylon. This caused them to be divided and thus to lose their oneness as a people for God's testimony. Their return from their captivity to the unique ground of Jerusalem (Deut. 12:5, 11-14) recovered this oneness. However, as we will see, in their return elements of the captivity returned with them.

C. Their return from their captivity recovering their enjoyment of the portion of the good land promised by God

God brought the children of Israel into His promised good land through His redemption and salvation that they might partake of the good land and enjoy it as their portion in God's economy. Because of their failure, they lost this portion of the good land in their captivity. Their return from their captivity recovered their enjoyment of the portion of the good land promised by God.

Those who are in today's denominations do not stress the enjoyment of Christ, and the denominational people are not taught, instructed, and directed to enjoy Christ. When I was with the denominations, I did not have any enjoyment of Christ. Only after I left the denominations did I begin to enjoy Christ.

Those who are in captivity are away from the good land, away from Christ. The Israelites who were captives in Babylon were away from the good land. Likewise, the Christians in the denominations are kept away by many things from the enjoyment of Christ. They have the name of Christ but not the enjoyment of Christ. If they would have the enjoyment of Christ, they must leave their captivity and come back to the proper ground where Christ, the good land, is.

D. God's intention to have His house built and His kingdom established on the earth

God intended to have His house built and His kingdom established on the earth through Israel's participation in and enjoyment of the good land. There would have been no way to accomplish this unless the children of Israel returned to the good land from their captivity.

Where is God's house and His kingdom today? Satan, the enemy of God, has usurped the earth. He has kept the earth as his house and as his kingdom. This has caused a great problem. Why does God need a people today? God needs a people because He wants a house where He is the Father and a kingdom where He is the King. The Lord needs His house and His kingdom in order to carry out His eternal economy. This is the reason God needs a return of His people from their captivity. God needs a house and a kingdom, and for this He needs the recovery.

All the foregoing crucial points are types typifying today's recovery of the church life, which is a recovery out of the church's captivity in the great Babylon (Rev. 17:1-6) back to the unique ground of God's choice.

VI. The sections

The book of Ezra has two sections: the return of the captivity under the kingly leadership of Zerubbabel (chs. 1—6) and the return of the captivity under the priestly leadership of Ezra (chs. 7—10).

The Return of the Captivity Under the Kingly Leadership of Zerubbabel

Scripture Reading: Ezra 1; Ezra 2; Ezra 3; Ezra 4; Ezra 5; Ezra 6

In this message we will consider the first return of the captivity, the return under the kingly leadership of Zerubbabel.

I. The decree of Cyrus king of Persia

The return of the captivity under the leadership of Zerubbabel was according to the decree of Cyrus king of Persia (Ezra 1:1-4; 2 Chron. 36:22-23).

A. In his first year

Cyrus made this decree in his first year (Ezra 1:1a).

B. By God's stirring up of his spirit

Cyrus made this decree because God stirred up his spirit (v. 1b). This stirring up was a work of the hiding God.

C. In fulfillment of the word of Jehovah by the mouth of Jeremiah

This decree was a fulfillment of the word of Jehovah by the mouth of Jeremiah that Israel would return after the seventieth year of their captivity in Babylon (v. 1b).

D. Ordering the captivity of Israel to go back to Jerusalem and rebuild the house of God

In his decree Cyrus ordered the captives of Israel to go back to Jerusalem and rebuild the house of God there (vv. 2-4). Because Cyrus was such a person, in the book of Isaiah he is considered a servant of God to fulfill God's purpose (Isa. 45:1-4, 13).

II. The response of the heads of the fathers' houses of Judah and Benjamin, the priests, and the Levites

In verses 5 and 6 we have a word concerning the response of the heads of the fathers' houses of Judah and Benjamin, the priests, and the Levites.

A. By God's stirring up of their spirit

Everyone whose spirit God had stirred up rose up to go up to build the house of Jehovah in Jerusalem (v. 5). This surely was God's move, for He stirred up the spirit of Cyrus to make the decree and then stirred up the spirits of all the leaders of the three tribes of Judah, Benjamin, and Levi.

B. All the Israelites around them strengthening their hands

All the Israelites around them strengthened their hands with their offerings of their precious vessels (v. 6).

III. The cooperation of King Cyrus

In verses 7 through 11 we see the cooperation of King Cyrus. He cooperated by returning the 5,400 vessels of gold and silver of the house of Jehovah, captured by Nebuchadnezzar from Jerusalem and put in the house of his gods (vv. 7, 11). He handed over the vessels, by enumerating them to Sheshbazzar (Zerubbabel — 2:2), the prince of Judah, to be brought back to Jerusalem for the house of God (1:8-11; 5:13-15).

IV. The number of the returned captives

In 2:1-67 we have a clear and accurate record of the number of the captives who returned under Zerubbabel, the prince of Judah (1:8), the governor of the former kingdom of Judah (2:2, 63). Of the Judites, the Benjaminites, the priests, the Levites, the temple servants, and the children of Solomon's servants (vv. 3-58), the total number was 42,360, besides their male and female servants and the male and female singers (vv. 64-65). In addition, 652 common people and three houses of priests who could not give evidence of their fathers' houses were included with those who returned under Zerubbabel (vv. 59-63).

V. The willing offering of some of the heads of the fathers' houses

Verses 68 and 69 speak of the willing offering of some of the heads of the fathers' houses, after their arrival at the house of Jehovah in Jerusalem, for the house of Jehovah to restore it on its foundation. This means the heads of the fathers' houses willingly offered their precious things to God for the rebuilding of the temple.

VI. The rebuilding of the altar of God

Ezra 3:1-6a is concerned with the rebuilding of the altar of God.

A. In the seventh month

They rebuilt the altar in the seventh month of the year of their return (v. 1a).

B. The children of Israel gathering to Jerusalem as one man

The children of Israel gathered from their cities to Jerusalem as one man (v. 1b). Not only the returned captives but also the Jews who had not been captured came to Jerusalem to rebuild the altar.

C. The altar being built upon its bases

Joshua the high priest and his brothers the priests and Zerubbabel the governor and his brothers built the altar of the God of Israel upon its bases, as written in the law of Moses, the man of God. Then, for God's satisfaction, they offered burnt offerings on it to Jehovah, as written in the law of Moses (vv. 2-3). Here we see that they did everything according to God's word.

D. Keeping the Feast of Tabernacles

They kept the Feast of Tabernacles and offered the daily burnt offerings and the offerings of the new moons and of all the appointed feasts of Jehovah (vv. 4-6a). This indicates that they recovered the worship of God, which had been lost for at least seventy years.

VII. The rebuilding of the house of God

In verses 6b through 13 we have a record of the rebuilding of the house of God.

A. Hiring stone hewers and carpenters

They hired stone hewers and carpenters, and they supplied the Sidonians and the Tyrians the daily necessities for them to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to Joppa (v. 7).

B. In the second month of the second year after their return

In the second month of the second year after their return, they began to rebuild the house of God with praise to Jehovah by the priests (vv. 8-13). Many of the priests and Levites and heads of the fathers' houses, the old men who had seen the first house, the original temple of God, wept with a loud voice when the foundation of this house was laid, and many shouted aloud for joy (v. 12). The people could not discern the sound of the shout of joy from the sound of the weeping of the people (v. 13).

VIII. The frustration

Chapter four gives us an account of the frustration to the rebuilding of the house of God.

A. The adversaries of Judah and Benjamin pretending to help the rebuilding of the house of Jehovah

The adversaries of Judah and Benjamin, people brought from Babylon and Assyria by the king of Assyria to inhabit Samaria (2 Kings 17:24), who imitated Israel in seeking God and sacrificing to God, pretended to help the rebuilding of the house of Jehovah, but they were rejected by Zerubbabel, Joshua, and the rest of the heads of the fathers' houses. The enemies hired counselors to frustrate the rebuilding throughout all the days of Cyrus king of Persia until the reign of Darius king of Persia, and in the beginning of the reign of Ahasuerus they wrote an accusation against the inhabitants of Judah and Jerusalem (Ezra 4:1-6). This typifies that today when we come back to the recovery to build the house of God, some nearby ones would make proposals that are mostly frustrations. This is Satan's subtlety. In his time, Zerubbabel saw through these proposals and rejected them.

B. Artaxerxes decreeing to stop the building of the house of God by force and power

In the days of Artaxerxes, a party of the inhabitants of Samaria and the rest of the lands beyond the River (maybe of the same adversaries in verse 1) wrote to Artaxerxes against Jerusalem. Artaxerxes decreed to stop the rebuilding of the house of God by force and power; and the work of the house of God ceased until the second year of the reign of Darius king of Persia (vv. 7-24).

IX. The continual rebuilding work

The rebuilding work continued through the encouragement and help of the prophecies of the prophets Haggai and Zechariah (5:1-2).

X. The confirmation of the decree of Darius king of Persia

Ezra 5:3—6:12 tells us of the confirmation of the decree of Darius king of Persia. After the people stopped the work, they were encouraged by the prophets Haggai and Zechariah to continue the rebuilding work. At the same time this work was confirmed by the decree of Darius king of Persia.

A. The rebuilding questioned and referred to Darius

The rebuilding was questioned and referred to Darius king of Persia by Tattenai, the governor beyond the River (that is, west of the Jordan) and his companions (vv. 3-17).

B. Darius's checking of the decree of Cyrus

In 6:1-12 we have Darius's checking of the decree of Cyrus and his confirmation to encourage and speed up the rebuilding. After being questioned about the rebuilding, Darius checked and confirmed the decree of Cyrus, finding out that Cyrus had issued a decree to release Israel from captivity so that they could go back to Jerusalem to rebuild the house of God. Darius confirmed that there was such a record, and his confirmation encouraged and sped up the rebuilding.

XI. The completion of the rebuilding of the house of God

Verses 13 through 15 describe the completion of the rebuilding of the house of God.

A. In prosperity

The rebuilding was completed in prosperity through the prophesying of the prophets Haggai and Zechariah (vv. 13-14).

B. On the third day of the month Adar

The work of rebuilding the house of Jehovah was completed on the third day of the month Adar, in the sixth year of the reign of Darius the king (v. 15).

XII. The dedication of the rebuilt house of God

Verses 16 through 18 speak of the dedication of the rebuilt house of God.

A. With joy

The dedication of the rebuilt house of God was with the joy of the priests, the Levites, and the rest of the children of the captivity in celebration (v. 16).

B. With the offerings for the dedication and a sin offering

The dedication was also with the offerings for the dedication and a sin offering for all the tribes of Israel (v. 17). This indicates that as they were offering burnt offerings for God's satisfaction, they could not forget their sin and therefore offered a sin offering.

C. With the setting up of the services of the priests and of the Levites

Finally, the rebuilt house was dedicated with the setting up of the services of the priests in their courses and of the Levites in their divisions, as written in the law of Moses (v. 18).

XIII. The keeping of the Passover by the children of the captivity

The account of the return of the captivity under the kingly leadership of Zerubbabel concludes with the keeping of the Passover by the children of the captivity (vv. 19-22). The Passover was a most important matter.

A. Having their priests and Levites purified

They kept the Passover by having their priests and Levites purified and themselves separated from the defilement of the nations in the good land (vv. 20-21).

B. Continuing with the feast of unleavened bread

They continued with the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days with joy, for Jehovah had made them joyful and had turned the heart of the king of Assyria to them, to strengthen their hands in the work of the house of God (v. 22). The king of Assyria was Darius king of Persia, because Assyria was at that time a part of Persia.

Today very few believers care for the building up of a proper local church in their locality as the house of God. This means that God is kept homeless. He does have a home in the heavens with the angels, but He needs a home with the humanity of His heart's desire. God wants to have such a home.

We in the Lord's recovery do not like to see the saints scattered individually. The particular intention of the recovery is to have all the saints in the recovery come together in their localities to be built up together as the house of God in so many cities. Through such a house God will have His kingdom.

We need to have a desire to be freed from self and the natural life in order to be built up with others (see Hymns, #840). To be built we need to be adjusted, disciplined, corrected, and transformed. Then we will be able to come together to be built as the house of God in many localities.

The Return of the Captivity Under the Priestly Leadership of Ezra

Scripture Reading: Ezra 7; Ezra 8; Ezra 9; Ezra 10

For God to fulfill His promise, spoken through Jeremiah, that the captivity would last only for seventy years (Jer. 25:11-12; Dan. 9:2), He accomplished two returns. The first return was under the leadership of Zerubbabel, a royal descendant. The second return was under the leadership of Ezra, a priest.

The first return did not need the priestly leadership of Ezra; rather, it needed the kingly leadership of Zerubbabel, a royal descendant who knew how to govern. Zerubbabel governed quite well, taking the lead in building up the altar and the temple. After this, the need shifted from the royal family to the priesthood, to Ezra, a descendant of the high priest Aaron. Ezra was not only a priest but also a scribe, someone who was skilled in the law of God (Ezra 7:6). As such a person, Ezra had the capacity to meet the need.

I. The return of the captivity under Ezra

Chapters seven and eight are concerned with the return of the captivity under Ezra.

A. The beginning of the return through the request of Ezra to the king

The return of the captivity under Ezra began through his request to the king (7:1-10). Ezra must have appealed to the king to give many of the Jews in his empire the freedom to go back to the land of their fathers. As we will see, the king not only granted Ezra's request but also provided everything he needed.

1. Ezra's genealogy

Ezra's genealogy in 7:1-5 indicates that he was a descendant of Aaron the chief priest.

2. The king's granting of the request of Ezra

The king granted the request of Ezra, a scribe skilled in the law of Moses (v. 6).

3. Coming safely to Jerusalem

Ezra, some of the children of Israel, some of the priests, the Levites, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants left Babylon on the first day of the first month in the seventh year of Artaxerxes the king and came safely to Jerusalem on the first day of the fifth month according to the good hand of God.

The book of Ezra does not speak of the Spirit of God, but the hand of God is mentioned a number of times (7:6, 9, 28; 8:31). What is the difference between the Spirit of God and the hand of God? When God's Spirit works inwardly, that is the Spirit. When God's Spirit works outwardly, that is God's hand.

4. Ezra having set his heart to seek and do the law of Jehovah

Ezra had set his heart to seek and do the law of Jehovah and to teach His statutes and ordinances (7:10). We need to see the difference between the statutes and the ordinances. The Ten Commandments are the main items of the law, but all these commandments have their statutes, which give the details. For instance, the fourth commandment is about keeping the Sabbath. The details regarding this commandment are found in the statutes. The ordinances are statutes to which judgments have been added. When a judgment is added to a statute, that statute becomes an ordinance. Regarding the commandment to keep the Sabbath, there are not only statutes giving the details but also ordinances telling of the judgment that will come upon those who break this commandment. Ezra set his heart not only to seek and do the main part of the law of Jehovah but also to teach His statutes, the details, and His ordinances, the verdicts and judgments.

B. The decree of Artaxerxes king of Persia

Verses 11 through 28 tell us about the decree of Artaxerxes king of Persia to Ezra the priest, the scribe.

1. Permitting the children of Israel, the priests, and the Levites to go to Jerusalem

The king permitted the children of Israel, the priests, and the Levites to go to Jerusalem as they willed, with silver and gold and vessels (vv. 12-19). This means that they were permitted to go freely with all their wealth.

2. Permitting the provision for the needs of the house of God

The king also permitted the provision for the needs of the house of God out of the king's treasure house (v. 20).

3. Ordering all the treasurers to provide whatever Ezra required for the house of God

The king went on to order all the treasurers in the lands beyond the Great River, the Euphrates, to provide whatever Ezra the priest required for the house of God (vv. 21-23).

4. Ordering the treasurers not to impose tribute, taxes, or tolls

Next, the king ordered the treasurers not to impose tribute, taxes, or tolls on the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, temple servants, or servants of this house of God (v. 24).

5. Authorizing Ezra to appoint magistrates and judges

According to verses 25 and 26 the king authorized Ezra to appoint magistrates and judges to judge the people in the land, to teach them the laws of his God, and to execute judgment according to the law of God and the law of the king. Here the king did something for his own advantage. Without a person such as Ezra, who would have been qualified to maintain a proper order among the people in the good land? In authorizing Ezra to appoint judges and magistrates, the king of Persia was clever, for he knew that the ones appointed by Ezra would execute judgment not only according to the law of God but also according to the law of the king.

6. Ezra's blessing to God

Verses 27 and 28 are Ezra's blessing to God. He blessed God for putting such a thing as this into the king's heart to beautify the house of Jehovah in Jerusalem, saying that God had extended lovingkindness to him before the king, before the king's counselors, and before all the mighty officers of the king. Then Ezra declared that he was strengthened according to the hand of Jehovah his God upon him. What the king did for Ezra, he did according to the hand of Jehovah. To some extent, the king, the counselors, and the mighty officers might have realized that God was with the Jews. God's hand was there, controlling everything sovereignly for the benefit of His elect.

C. The genealogical enrollment

In 8:1-20 we have the genealogical enrollment of those who returned from their captivity back to Jerusalem.

D. Ezra's proclamation of a fast

Ezra proclaimed a fast before they left Babylon, to humble themselves before God to seek from Him a straight way for them, rather than to ask for troops and horsemen from the king to help them against the enemy in the way (vv. 21-23). Instead of asking for troops, which the king would have provided, Ezra put his trust in the good hand of God.

E. Ezra setting apart twelve of the leading men of the priests

Ezra set apart twelve of the leading men of the priests to take care of the offerings of silver, gold, and vessels for the house of God and to bring them to the house of God in Jerusalem (vv. 24-30). This was a serious responsibility, for it involved risk and danger on the journey from Babylon to Jerusalem.

F. The journey and arrival of the returned captivity

Verses 31 through 34 describe the journey and arrival of the returned captivity.

1. Setting out from the river Ahava

They set out from the river Ahava on the twelfth day of the first month, having the hand of their God upon them, who delivered them from the hand of the enemy and from people set in ambush on the way (v. 31).

2. Arriving at Jerusalem and delivering all the silver, gold, and vessels

They arrived at Jerusalem and delivered all the silver, gold, and vessels to the house of God by weighing them (vv. 32-34). This indicates that they delivered this wealth in a very careful way.

G. The offerings to God by the returned captivity

Verse 35 speaks of the offerings to God by the returned captivity. As soon as they arrived, they offered burnt offerings and a sin offering.

H. The returned captivity's delivering the king's decrees

The returned captivity delivered the king's decrees to the king's satraps and to the governors of the provinces beyond the River, and these supported the people and the house of God (v. 36).

II. The purification of the returned captives from the defilement of the foreign wives

Chapters nine and ten are an account of the purification of the returned captives from the defilement of the foreign wives. God had charged the children of Israel, when they entered into the good land, not to have intermarriage with the peoples of the land. At Ezra's time, not only the common people but even the priests and the Levites had foreign wives.

A. Initiated by the officials of the returned captives

This purification was initiated by the officials of the returned captives (9:1-2). They accused the people of Israel, the priests, and the Levites of not separating themselves from the peoples of the lands but taking the daughters of the nations for themselves and for their sons, thus mingling the holy seed with the peoples of abominations. They accused the leaders and the rulers of having been foremost in this unfaithfulness to God.

B. Ezra's reaction

Verses 3 through 15 describe Ezra's reaction.

1. Tearing his garment

Ezra tore his garment and pulled out hair from his head and his beard and sat down appalled with the gathering of those who trembled at the words of the God of Israel (vv. 3-4). Those who trembled at the words of God were the faithful ones.

2. Making a thorough confession of the iniquities of the children of Israel

Ezra then made a thorough confession of the iniquities of the children of Israel from their forefathers' time to their time, saying that their iniquities issued in the delivery of their kings and their priests into the hand of the kings of the lands and into captivity and shamefacedness (vv. 5-7).

3. Thanking God for leaving them a remnant to escape

Ezra thanked God for leaving them a remnant to escape and for giving them a peg in His holy place by extending His lovingkindness to them in the sight of the kings of Persia to give them a reviving, to raise up the house of their God, and to give them a wall and to repair its ruins in Judah and Jerusalem (vv. 8-9).

4. Confessing their being defiled

Ezra continued by confessing their being defiled with the uncleanness and abominations of the Canaanites in seeking their peace and prosperity, thus losing the right to enjoy the good of the promised land and to leave it for an inheritance to their children forever (vv. 10-15). Ezra was confessing that by taking foreign wives the people were despising and neglecting their right to enjoy the good land and as a result they were given by God into captivity.

C. The congregation's reaction

In 10:1-5 we have the congregation's reaction.

1. Weeping very bitterly for their unfaithfulness against their God

The people reacted by weeping very bitterly for their unfaithfulness against their God by marrying foreign women from the peoples of the land (vv. 1-2).

2. Making a covenant with their God

They also made a covenant with their God to put away all their foreign wives and those born of them, according to the counsel of Ezra and of those who trembled at the commandment of their God (v. 3).

3. Encouraging Ezra to be strong and bear his responsibility

The people encouraged Ezra to be strong and bear his responsibility. Then they swore that they would do according to his word (vv. 4-5).

D. The final decision

Ezra 10:6-44 is a record of the final decision. A proclamation was made throughout Judah and Jerusalem to all the children of Israel to gather in Jerusalem within three days (vv. 6-9). Next, the decision was made to separate themselves from the peoples of the land and from the foreign women (vv. 10-14, 16-17). However, a few of the people stood up against the decision, supported by one Levite (v. 15). Finally, there was a list of all the men who had married foreign women (vv. 18-44).

We have pointed out that Ezra emphasizes the matter of God's hand. It was by His hand that God gave the children of Israel into captivity. It was also by His hand that God brought the children of Israel back from their captivity to the land of their forefathers. Here we see that the same God did two different things: He gave His people to their enemy as captives and He delivered them from captivity and brought them back to their fatherland. Ezra, a wise man, was clear about this.

Ezra realized that the first return was not perfect, not complete. He realized that there was the need for someone who was skilled in the law of God to help the people to know God not merely in a general way but according to what God had spoken. Ezra had such a capacity, so he volunteered himself to go to the king and to request a decree from the king permitting the Jews to do everything freely.

Chapter one of Ezra tells us that God stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia to make a proclamation concerning the rebuilding of the house of God (vv. 1-2) and that He also stirred up the spirit of the heads of the fathers' houses of Judah and Benjamin, the priests, and the Levites to go up to build the house of God in Jerusalem (v. 5). God was hiding Himself, but at the expiration of the seventy years, He came in to stir up the spirit of Cyrus. Cyrus must have been happy that the great empire of Babylon was in his hand, and regarding the Jews he might have wanted to do something that was opposite to what the Babylonians had done. Humanly speaking, Cyrus took the initiative to make the decree. Actually, this was initiated by God in a hidden way. Therefore, the first return from Babylon to Jerusalem was initiated by God.

The second return was initiated by Ezra, a priest and a scribe skilled in the Word of God. Ezra came to the king and appealed to him to grant his request (7:6). From this we see that sometimes God personally stirs us up in our spirit to do something for Him. However, often God is quiet, realizing that it is better that we do something because we have the capacity, as Ezra had. In this kind of situation, God is responsible for the things we do. Whether the things are stirred up by Him or stirred up by us, He will be in them, stretching out His hand to do everything to help us.

The Need for Ezras — Those Skilled in the Word of God

Scripture Reading: Ezra 7:6, 10; 1:7-11

The Bible is unique, and everything contained in it is significant. At the very beginning, the Bible tells us that God created Adam as a creature in His kind (Gen. 1:26). Adam was God's kind only in likeness and appearance, not in life, nature, and constitution. God's desire was that Adam would be His kind not only in likeness but also in life, nature, and constitution.

God's intention that Israel would be His testimony

In Genesis 3:15 God promised that He would come to be the seed of woman. Later, He prophesied further He would come to be a seed of Abraham, which would be the blessing to all the nations (22:18). Eventually, God Himself was incarnated to be a man. However, God first, through His continuous labor, took more than one thousand years to produce and form the nation of Israel as a great type.

God selected Abraham, whose descendants fell into Egypt. God sent Moses to them to deliver them out of Egypt as a great nation, numbering about two million, and brought them to Mount Sinai, where they stayed for nearly a year to be educated by God. God's intention was to have Israel as His testimony, but according to their Egyptian culture they were a testimony of Egypt. For this reason God kept them at Mount Sinai to give them the Ten Commandments, all the statutes for the Ten Commandments, all the ordinances for the statutes, the tabernacle with all the furniture and all the offerings, the priesthood, and all the feasts, in order to build them up with a heavenly, divine constitution instead of an Egyptian constitution.

The nation of Israel being God-men in typology but eventually becoming degraded

As a result of this time of education and training, the nation of Israel became an army not only formed and organized but also constituted to be God with man and man with God. Hence, in typology the Israelites were God-men. They were God-men, and everything related to them, even their environment with the pillar of cloud in the day and the pillar of fire at night, was God's expression. Their going forth became God's going forth (Psa. 68).

After a short time, however, the children of Israel no longer expressed God, and He let them die in the wilderness. Then God raised up the second generation, and they crossed the river Jordan by a great miracle. As a heavenly constituted army they came to Jericho. When they shouted, the city of Jericho fell. This was God's testimony. This was the move, the living, of God-men; it was God marching on. But when they came to the city of Ai, one among them caused them to fail. From that time onward, there was nothing among the Israelites but degradation. God sent the prophets to warn them and bring them back, but they refused to go along with God. Eventually, God brought in the Babylonians to possess the good land and carry the people of Israel away to Babylon to be disciplined and punished.

The return of God's people under Zerubbabel

God could not forget the good land, the promised land, the land of Immanuel (Isa. 8:8). The good land should be the land of God-men for the testimony of God. First, there was a return under the leadership of Zerubbabel, a descendant of the royal family. It was fitting for him to take the lead in the first return from captivity, because he had the capacity to administrate and to govern. He was a strong governor and he led the people in rebuilding the temple with the altar.

The need for an Ezra

However, the people were still unruly, for they had become Babylonian in their constitution. Therefore, there was the need for an Ezra, a priest who served God, and also a scribe, a scholar, who was skilled in the Word of God, skilled in the law of Moses (Ezra 7:6, 11). He bore the totality of the heavenly and divine constitution and culture. Ezra called the people together and confessed not only his own sin but also the sin of Israel, to bring them back to the Word of God.

The responsibility of the elders to teach the saints with the truths

In the church life today, the main responsibility of the elders is to teach the saints with the truths. The Bible says that one of the qualifications of an elder is being apt to teach (1 Tim. 3:2). Paul tells us that certain elders may not have a job but may “labor in word and teaching” and therefore should be supported by the church (5:17-18). However, I have observed that some elders are deficient in the knowledge of the truth and may not even be clear whether a particular matter is an item of the truth.

Let me check with you about calling on the name of the Lord. Is calling on the name of the Lord a truth? No, it is not a truth. Calling on the Lord is necessary, and we need to have such a practice in our daily life, but calling on the Lord’s name is not a truth. Likewise, baptism, presbytery, footwashing, and pray-reading are not truths. On the other hand, justification by faith is a truth. Regeneration, sanctification, renewing, transformation, conformation, transfiguration, being made God in life and in nature but not in the Godhead — all these are truths.

Some elders may speak about life-practices such as calling on the Lord, pray-reading, praying without ceasing, not quenching the Spirit, and not despising prophesying, but they do not know how to teach the truths to the saints. For example, if these ones are asked about sanctification, they may be able to say only that to be sanctified is to be separated unto God. If they are asked about the difference between sanctification and renewing, they may not be able to explain the difference. Therefore, I say once again that all the elders need to know the truths and be able to teach the truths to others.

All the elders need to spend much time to learn the truths. This is the duty, the responsibility, of an elder. Anyone who accepts an appointment to the eldership must fulfill this responsibility. Like Ezra, all the elders and co-workers must be skilled in the Word of God.

A great famine throughout the earth

Throughout the whole earth there is a great famine of God’s Word. In Christianity today, both in Catholicism and in Protestantism, there is very little teaching of the truth. In many places, instead of the truth there are superstitions and pagan practices. For instance, in all of Latin America there is very little of the truth. I believe that this is the reason why our publications, which are full of the truth, are so well received there. In Latin America the people who love God also love our publications. These publications cover the entire Bible from the first page to the last.

The need for Ezras to constitute the people with the heavenly truths

Both Brother Nee and I spent a great deal of time in learning to be skillful in the Word. Much of what we have learned has been put into print. We have almost completed the life-study of the Scriptures, and we have begun what we call the crystallization study. Today there is the need not just for Zerubbabels but for more Ezras. It would be unseemly for an elder to make decisions and expect the saints to follow them but not visit the saints with the truths. The real eldership is not to exercise authority. The real eldership is to visit the saints and to shepherd them, feed them, and take care of them by speaking to them concerning the truths. Today we need Ezras to teach the people, to educate them, and to constitute them with the heavenly truths.

Types of the riches of Christ

I thank the Lord that, even though we are still so short in many ways, He, for His own sake, has spread His recovery, with His riches, to more than two thousand cities throughout the earth. When the Israelites went back to Jerusalem, they were stirred up, they rose up, they went up, and they brought up 5,400 vessels of gold and silver (Ezra 1:7-11). These were the vessels which Nebuchadnezzar had brought out from Jerusalem and had put in the house of his gods. During the first return from the captivity, all these vessels were brought back to Jerusalem. Those vessels are types of the riches of Christ. After I came to this country, I released messages on the riches of Christ, and I also wrote a hymn on the unsearchable riches of Christ (Hymns, #542). In Ephesians 3:8 Paul speaks not only of Christ’s riches but of Christ’s unsearchable riches. Today the enjoyment of the riches of Christ is by His word.

The Lord moving in His recovery by His word

In His recovery the Lord is moving by His word, by the truth. His word is in the Bible, but the Bible needs the proper interpretation, which is found in the life-studies. If the co-workers and the elders study all our publications, there will be many Ezras in the Lord’s recovery to constitute people with the heavenly truths.